

What went wrong? Jar display

Category	Display - Passive engagement - Conversation starter
Skill level	Experienced MFP recommended. The display runs itself, but the best conversations come from a volunteer who can answer detailed questions - lean on the talking-points sheet.
Audience	Adults & Teens. A "spot the problem" display of jars showing common canning mistakes, with answer tags (Safe / Not Safe / Discard).
Setup time	15-20 minutes (recreate the example jars)

Some example jars are UNSAFE on purpose. Keep them clearly labeled "DISPLAY ONLY - DO NOT EAT," never let anyone taste a display jar, and discard spoiled examples safely (sealed bag) after the event. Run by an experienced MFP where possible.

DESCRIPTION

A display of jars showing common canning problems - improper headspace, failed seals, discoloration, crystallization, un-acidified tomatoes - with tent cards that ask "Can you spot what went wrong?" Visitors guess, then read the tag (Safe / Not Safe / Discard) and the explanation. It runs itself when you are busy and sparks excellent teaching moments. 18 scenarios; a tablet "spot the problem" quiz is included.

MATERIALS NEEDED

Print (the display)

- The "jar-tags.pdf" - a tag for each example jar (Safe / Not Safe / Discard + the explanation + how to prevent). Cut and attach one to each jar.
- The "table-signage.pdf" - the "Can you spot what went wrong?" table sign.
- The "Setup guide" (setup-guide.pdf) - how to recreate each example jar.
- The "Volunteer talking points" (volunteer-talking-points.pdf) - deeper answers for when visitors ask.

Digital version (tablet)

- Open the quiz: sign in to the MFP Volunteer Resource Hub, tap "Outreach," then "Play on tablet" on the What went wrong? card. Read the jar, guess Safe / Not Safe / Discard, and reveal the answer.

Both

- Your own example jars (recreate them from the Setup guide), labels, table and MFP / OSU Extension signage.
- This Activity guide on the table.

SETUP

1. Use the Setup guide to recreate the example jars from your own jars. Label every unsafe jar "DISPLAY ONLY - DO NOT EAT."
2. Print and cut the jar tags; attach one to each jar. Set out the table sign.
3. Keep the Volunteer talking points next to you.

ACTIVITY DIRECTIONS

Running it

1. Let visitors look at the jars and guess: Safe, Not Safe, or Discard?
2. Have them read the tag to check, then talk through what went wrong and how to prevent it.
3. Use the talking points for deeper questions; point out the HIGH-risk ones (failed seal, low-acid water-bathed)

especially.

4. Refer "is my jar safe?" questions to a Master Food Preserver.

VOLUNTEER NOTES

- Keep the talking-points sheet handy - it has the deeper "why" for every jar.
- Never let anyone taste a display jar; unsafe examples are for looking only.
- The DISCARD jars are the most important teaching moments - explain why they cannot be saved.
- Accuracy matters: read the tags as written; refer detailed questions to a Master Food Preserver.
- No tablet? The printed tags and signs run the display on their own.